

UNIT 8 Mayday, Mayday

The Marina has weathered the storm and the situation seems to be under control. But not everybody has been so lucky. Suddenly the radio comes alive. The DSC starts sounding and the following distress acknowledgement can be read on the Marina's receiver:

ALL SHIPS
002275000
DISTRESS
250137000
FIRE EXPLOSION
47° 34' N 004° 33' W
1032 UTC

Soon after the following message from the vessel in distress is heard on channel 16:

MAYDAY
THIS IS
250137000
OCEAN KING
CALL SIGN SIERRA OSCAR ZULU ZULU
POSITION: 47° 34.4' NORTH 004° 32.9' WEST
EXPLOSION ON BOARD. HEAVY LEAKAGE.
LISTING
REQUIRE IMMEDIATE ASSISTANCE
OVER

Almost immediately there is an acknowledgement by the Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre (MRCC) followed by radio messages from nearby ships:

MAYDAY
OCEAN KING OCEAN KING OCEAN KING
THIS IS RESCUE CENTRE ÉTEL
RESCUE CENTRE ÉTEL RESCUE CENTRE ÉTEL
RECEIVED MAYDAY
OVER

Then comes the first answer from a ship in the vicinity answered by the vessel in distress:

MAYDAY
OCEAN KING OCEAN KING OCEAN KING.
SIERRA OSCAR ZULU ZULU
THIS IS UTOPIA UTOPIA UTOPIA
CALL SIGN: KILO LIMA OSCAR ALPHA.
RECEIVED MAYDAY.

MAYDAY
OCEAN KING
THIS IS UTOPIA
MY POSITION
LATITUDE: 47° 28.1' NORTH
LONGITUDE: 004° 08.5' WEST
SPEED: 18 KNOTS
ETA: 1130 UTC
OVER.

MAYDAY
UTOPIA. THIS IS OCEAN KING.
UNDERSTOOD.
POSITION: TIME: 1032 UTC
LATITUDE: 47° 28.1' NORTH
LONGITUDE: 004° 08.5' WEST
SPEED: 18 KNOTS
ETA: 1130 UTC
OVER.

After a little while the Rescue centre sends a mayday relay:

MAYDAY RELAY MAYDAY RELAY MAYDAY RELAY

ALL STATIONS ALL STATIONS ALL STATIONS

This is Rescue Centre Étel, Rescue Centre Étel, Rescue Centre Étel.

Ocean King Information No 1. Following received from Ocean King on VHF channel 16 at 1032 UTC.

Begins:

Mayday

This is 250137000

Ocean King, SOZZ.

In position 47° 34,4' NORTH 004° 32, 9' WEST

Explosion on board, heavy leakage, listing.

Require immediate assistance.

Ends.

Date and time: 151035 UTC. This is Rescue Centre Étel.

Over.

Many ships start calling in to assist Ocean King. They are all much closer to the scene of the accident, but Captain James on the Marina gives orders to stand by if her assistance should be required.

The Radio Officer sends the following message on channel 16:

MAYDAY

RESCUE CENTRE ÉTEL RESCUE CENTRE ÉTEL RESCUE CENTRE ÉTEL

THIS IS 2320026754

MARINA MARINA MARINA

MIKE WHISKEY YANKEE ALPHA THREE

RECEIVED MAYDAY

OVER

MAYDAY

RESCUE CENTRE ÉTEL

THIS IS MARINA

MIKE WHISKEY YANKEE ALPHA THREE

MY POSITION IS 47° 26.5' NORTH

003° 59.3' WEST

SPEED 14 KNOTS

MY ETA IS 1215 UTC

In this radio communication the ships were equipped in accordance with GMDSS. A distress call was sent by DSC (Digital Selective Call) from Ocean King, the vessel in distress. The call reached the rescue centre in the vicinity and an acknowledgement was sent out. This could be seen on the DSC receiver by all ships nearby. After that Ocean King sent a voice distress message on channel 16. This was answered by the rescue centre and by the ships that received it.

Later on the Bridge...

After a while the Marina receives a radio message from the Rescue Centre to the effect that her assistance is no longer required. As the situation now seems to be under control the men can relax a bit. Thoughts go back to earlier experiences.

- Do you remember the Viking Princess last year, John? Captain James asks.
- Indeed I do, I remember the incident very well.
- What incident was that, asks Timo, whose curiosity has been aroused.
- This was when you were on sick leave Timo, says John. It was last year that we received a mayday message from The Viking Princess in the English Channel. She was a very small vessel and had engine trouble. When the Marina arrived she was sinking.
- Captain James first went to windward of the Viking Princess and lay with the wind on the weather bow. I had a lifeboat lowered on the leeward side, we took her to the Viking Princess and managed to take on the distressed crew.
- I remember the sea was quite rough, it was cold and the poor chaps from the Viking Princess were rather shaken up.
- Boy, were they grateful when we arrived in time!
- Yes, you were quite the hero there, weren't you John, teases Captain James.

IMPORTANT STRUCTURES

Now let's see how a mayday message is built up on channel 16 after a Distress Call by DSC:

- Mayday
- This is...
- Ship's MMSI number, 9 digits
- Ship's name and call sign (once)
- Position: Latitude, Longitude
- What is wrong
- Over

A) A distress message

MAYDAY

THIS IS + Name, call sign or other identification of the vessel in distress 3 x

POSITION : Latitude, longitude or bearing to known geographical position

NATURE OF THE DISTRESS

THE KIND OF ASSISTANCE REQUIRED

ANY OTHER INFORMATION THAT MIGHT FACILITATE RESCUE

OVER

B) Acknowledgement by radio telephone

MAYDAY

Name, call sign or other identification of vessel in distress 3 x

THIS IS + name, call sign or other identification of answering vessel / station 3 x

RECEIVED MAYDAY

C) Assistance information message

MAYDAY

Name, call sign or other identification of the vessel in distress

THIS IS + name, call sign or other identification of assisting vessel

POSITION of assisting vessel

SPEED of assisting vessel

ETA of assisting vessel

OVER

Let's have a closer look at how a mayday message is built up (on channel 16 after a DSC Call has been made).

MAYDAY
THIS IS
250137000
OCEAN KING
CALL SIGN SIERRA OSCAR ZULU ZULU
POSITION: 47° 34.4' NORTH 004° 32.9' WEST
EXPLOSION ON BOARD. HEAVY LEAKAGE.
LISTING
REQUIRE IMMEDIATE ASSISTANCE
OVER

And now let's study the answer to a distress message:

MAYDAY
OCEAN KING, OCEAN KING, OCEAN KING
250137000
SIERRA OSCAR ZULU ZULU
THIS IS UTOPIA UTOPIA UTOPIA
CALL SIGN: KILO LIMA OSCAR ALPHA
RECEIVED MAYDAY

MAYDAY
OCEAN KING
THIS IS UTOPIA
MY POSITION
LATITUDE: 47° 28.1' NORTH
LONGITUDE: 004° 08.5' WEST
SPEED: 18 [ONE-EIGHT] KNOTS
ETA: 1130 [ONE-ONE-THREE-ZERO] UTC
OVER

The answer to a distress message consists of two parts: a) acknowledgement b) assistance information message.